GOULD-BERG VARIATIONS

23 POEMS

EN



Premiere:

29.9.2026
19:30
Divadlo Inspirace*

Performances:

30.9., 1.10., 2.10.2026
19:30
Divadlo Inspirace*

* Malostranské náměstí 258/13, 118 00 Praha 1 – Malá Strana

J.S. Bach

and His Goldberg Variations, BWV 988

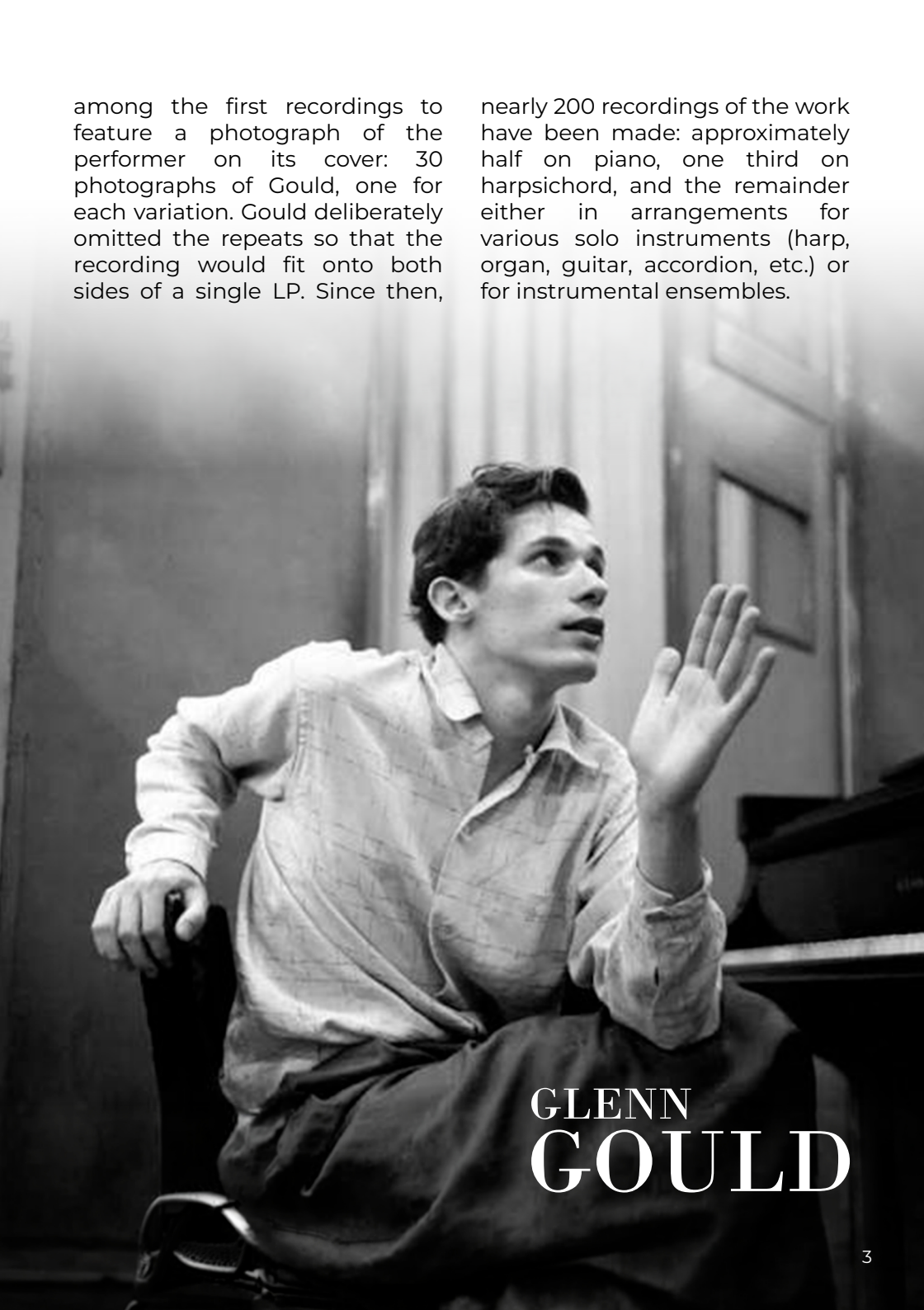
"Aria mit verschiedenen Veränderungen" ("Aria with Diverse Variations") was the title Johann Sebastian Bach (1685–1750) gave to BWV 988 when the work was first published by his friend Balthasar Schmid in Nuremberg in 1741.

The Goldberg Variations constitute a vast display of contrapuntal and structural mastery. The Aria is a sarabande, a noble triple-meter dance with occasional emphasis on the second beat of the measure. The richly ornamented melody of the Aria, however, does not form the basis for the variations that follow, as one might expect; rather, it is its harmonic structure and bass line that provide their foundation. All the subsequent variations adhere to the same harmonic plan, although three of them are in G minor rather than G major. The return of the Aria at the end of the work provides a poignant and entirely fitting conclusion to the entire cycle.

Every third variation is a canon at successively expanding intervals, progressing from the canon at the unison (Variation 3) to the canon at the ninth (Variation 27). The final variation, however, interrupts this sequence: instead of a canon, we find a Quodlibet, in which Bach quotes several German folk songs. Throughout the cycle, Bach employs a wide range of keyboard techniques, from expressive lyricism to brilliant virtuoso passages. At the same time, he presents a remarkably broad array of musical idioms, including the fughetta, toccata, and various Baroque dances, as well as references to his Italian and French contemporaries and their styles of composition for keyboard instruments.

After Bach's death in 1750, The Goldberg Variations fell into almost complete oblivion and remained so until the twentieth century, with only a handful of recordings emerging during the first half of the century. It was Glenn Gould's 1955 recording that finally brought The Goldberg Variations to the forefront of public attention and into the awareness of a broad musical audience. Gould's LP was also

among the first recordings to feature a photograph of the performer on its cover: 30 photographs of Gould, one for each variation. Gould deliberately omitted the repeats so that the recording would fit onto both sides of a single LP. Since then, nearly 200 recordings of the work have been made: approximately half on piano, one third on harpsichord, and the remainder either in arrangements for various solo instruments (harp, organ, guitar, accordion, etc.) or for instrumental ensembles.





WHY GOLDBERG VARIATIONS NOW?

Oops! Not Goldberg. **GOULD-berg Variations!**

Yes! It is indeed a reference to Canadian pianist - Glenn Gould, famous for his eccentric character, endless humming (while playing!) and most importantly - a radical interpretation of Bach's Variations.

Anyway, why would anyone want to mess with an already perfect piece of classical music and litter it with movement, lights, props, etc. As if Bach's masterpiece were not quite enough. Why go off the beaten track?

In all honesty, we did start with ultimate respect for Bach and his music. We are not there to re-interpret or re-invent Bach. Rather, we are there to allow Bach to unlock our own eccentricity, our own imagination, our own creative freedom and our own potential for connection with another artist, dead or alive. It took weeks, no, months of discussions, improvisations, rehearsals to find our own vision of Bach's music. We are presenting our first draft of a show to our first public. In fact, this show will always be a draft because we are still letting Bach push us in new directions.

For now, the piece is coming to life through three intersecting layers. The first one is obvious. It's a story about a precocious page-

turner and a serious classical pianist. The story seems simple and, hopefully, humourous too. Why humourous? Because we ourselves felt there was a lot of playful humour in Bach and even more humour and playfulness in how Glenn Gould interpreted the famous Variations.

The next layer is a metaphorical one. This one is a lot more open to interpretation and everyone is welcome to build their own story or even their own mythology around the stage images and sounds that we have put together. Everyone is welcome to rely on their own associations, life histories, fears and joys while engaging with the performance. Some will probably relate to the themes of extreme solitude, creative self-torture and overwhelming nightmarish obsessions that all creative souls experience. Others would prefer to focus on the idea of kindness and collaboration in the time of psychological difficulty: when someone goes rogue, we should have the capacity to accept them with kindness and curiosity, just like the pianist in our piece accepts the page-turner. This in turn leads to new discoveries, inventions and collaborations - and, more importantly, collective joy.

The third and last layer is there specifically for nerds and nerds only, especially Glenn Gould nerds. But if you miss this layer, that wouldn't be a problem. It's the icing on top.

Naturally, we remain open to YOUR own visions of the three layers, especially the metaphorical one. In the end, no one owns the 'correct' interpretation of Bach, although some very serious people claim that they do.

Guess what - no one owns the 'correct' interpretation of our performance either. So, go ahead! Co-imagine, co-construct, co-question. And Enjoy!

Yours,

Eliška, Radka, and Art

Creative Team

Eliška Benešová is a Czech dancer, educator, creator, and performer. She studied dance at the Prague Conservatory of Dance, the Duncan Centre Conservatory, and abroad at the Escuela Profesional de Danza de Mazatlán in Mexico. In 2023, she founded 23 Poems Collective z. s. with the aim of supporting international and multidisciplinary collaboration. She has been working as a teacher at the Duncan Centre Conservatory for many years and is a certified instructor of the international movement education programme Fighting Monkey.

Radka Hanáková is a Czech-Canadian concert pianist, chamber musician, and educator. She studied at the Academy of Performing Arts in Prague (HAMU) under Prof. Miroslav Langer, and later was admitted to the prestigious Artist Diploma programme at the Glenn Gould School. She received her doctorate from the University of Toronto under the supervision of Prof. Jamie Parker, and in 2020 released her debut solo album dedicated to Bach's Goldberg Variations.

Art Babayants is a Canadian theatre director, artist, educator, and academic of Armenian heritage. He holds a PhD in Drama, Theatre and Performance Studies from the University of Toronto and is the Artistic Director of the independent theatre company Toronto Laboratory Theatre. His artistic and academic work focuses on contemporary music theatre, multilingual dramaturgy, and the integration of acting techniques. He is the creator and director of numerous internationally acclaimed theatre projects.



CREDITS

Direction and Dramaturgy: **Art Babayants** · Music: **Johann Sebastian Bach** · Musical Interpretation: **Radka Hanáková** · Choreography and Dance Performance: **Eliška Benešová** · Movement Collaboration: **Cécile Da Costa** · Lighting Design: **Art Babayants**, **Martin Bitala** · Set Design: **Martina Koblic Valterová**, **Josef Koblic** · Technical Realization: **Martin Bitala** · Production and Promotion: 23 **Poems Collective z. s.** · Co-production: **Toronto Laboratory Theatre** · Photography and video: **Karolína Šnajdrová**

The project is financially supported by the **Ministry of Culture of the Czech Republic, the State Culture Fund of the Czech Republic, and Prague 1 Municipal District and le Conseil des arts et des lettres du Québec**

The project has also been supported by Divadlo Inspirace, Studio Truhlárna, Komunitní prostor Smíchov, Duncan Centre Conservatory

WITH THE SUPPORT OF:

MINISTRY OF CULTURE CZECH REPUBLIC

Státní fond kultury ČR

PRAHA 1

CALQ Conseil des arts et des lettres du Québec

komunitní prostor smíchov

TRUHLARNA

HAMU